

Surgery for peritoneal mesothelioma

Surgery is only suitable for a small number of people with peritoneal mesothelioma.

On this page

- [Surgery for peritoneal mesothelioma](#)
- [Surgery to remove the peritoneum \(peritonectomy\).](#)
- [Chemotherapy into the abdomen \(HIPEC\).](#)
- [How we can help](#)

Surgery for peritoneal mesothelioma

A small number of people with peritoneal [mesothelioma](#) may be offered surgery. This is called complete cytoreductive surgery (CRS) and hyperthermic intraperitoneal chemotherapy (HIPEC).

Whether this treatment is suitable for you depends on many different things. These include:

- the [type of mesothelioma](#)
- the location of the mesothelioma in the tummy area
- if the surgeon thinks it is possible to completely remove the mesothelioma
- your general fitness.

The operation will be done by a surgeon who is experienced in treating peritoneal mesothelioma. You will need to travel to a specialist centre for this surgery. If your specialist offers you surgery, they will give you more information about what to expect.

Surgery to remove the peritoneum (peritonectomy)

The surgeon will remove most of your [peritoneum](#). This is called a peritonectomy. They may also have to remove affected nearby organs. These may include the spleen, the gallbladder, and sometimes part of the bowel. You may also need to have the womb and ovaries removed. People who have a womb and ovaries include women, transgender (trans) men and people assigned female at birth.

If you need part of the bowel removed, you may need to have a bag fitted on your tummy to collect your stools (poo). This is called a [stoma](#). The stoma may be temporary or permanent, depending on the situation.

During the surgery, the surgeon will remove as much of the tumours as they can see. Then they will put a heated chemotherapy drug directly into your tummy. This is called hyperthermic intraperitoneal chemotherapy (HIPEC).

Chemotherapy into the abdomen (HIPEC)

If you are having surgery for peritoneal mesothelioma, your doctor may suggest having chemotherapy into the tummy (abdomen) during the surgery. This is called HIPEC (hyperthermic intraperitoneal chemotherapy).

This treatment is usually only suitable for a small number of people.

During the operation, the surgeon removes all, or most, of the tumours they can see. They then wash out the area to try to remove any loose mesothelioma cells, and put chemotherapy into the tummy (abdomen).

The chemotherapy drugs used are usually [doxorubicin](#) and [cisplatin](#). The chemotherapy is gently heated before being put in your tummy. This can help it work better for this type of cancer.

The side effects of giving chemotherapy this way can be different to giving chemotherapy into a vein. Your doctor or nurse will explain what to expect.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our mesothelioma cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Kusamura S, Kepenekian V, Villeneuve L, Lurvink RJ, Govaerts K, De Hingh IHJT, Moran BJ, Van der Speeten K, Deraco M, Glehen O; PSOGI. Peritoneal mesothelioma: PSOGI/EURACAN clinical practice guidelines for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. Eur J Surg Oncol. 2021 Vol, 47(1) pp6-59. [accessed April 2024].

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.

Email the Macmillan Support Line



Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

An anonymous network of people affected by mesothelioma which is free to join. Share experiences, ask questions and talk to people who understand.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help